

ARTS CRAFTS GALLERIES

Maurice Sievan's hallucinatory types

Maurice Sievan was born in the Ukraine in 1898. He came to this country in 1909, and studied art here, among others with Leon Kroll and Charles Hawthorne and in Paris with Andre L'Hote.

Sievan painted portraits from the beginning, but is best known for urban landscapes in Queens, the New York City borough. Their style is rooted in Corot and the French Impressionists, but is much freer. He used a vigorous calligraphic brush-stroke before it became fashionable.

Sievan worked from nature until an airplane trip to Europe, when he saw a horizonless world below him. Thereafter he painted from imagination. Some of the earliest of the new paintings were strange, looming colossal figures made from 1959 to 1963; they were first shown in 1963, and aroused considerable interest. One (lent to this exhibit) was bought by the

Museum of Modern Art.

Twelve of these large figures are being shown at Vanderwoude Tananbaum Gallery in New York City, for the first time in many years. Their overall effect is sensual, mysterious, even awesome and ominous. The canvases are large, slightly taller than the average person; and the figures almost fill the canvases. They consist of thin washes of paint with calligraphic outlines. On some there is further development of superimposed planes of paint. Most of the figures are clearly humanoid, with discernible head, shoulders and gown-like garments.

The colors are especially interesting—strange colors one can hardly remember seeing before, and beautifully combined: dark magenta, grayish greens and lavenders, green grays, plum brown and odd whites. The canvases are fundamentally dark, and this assists development of extraordinary luminosity in some paler colors. The paint is basically rather dirty and serious-looking.

All these figures verge on abstraction; one can draw strong parallels with color-field painting (especially of Rothko's color clouds) to gestural abstraction, and to the boldness of invention and scale of abstract expressionism. Sievan thought there was no relation, but these paintings are hardly imaginable before the 1950s. Certainly the example of the New York School liberated him to create them.

Sievan was strongly intellectual, and loved music and literature. Some of his images came from reading, especially in Poe and Beckett. He strongly admired and was influenced by



Maurice Sievan, "Mertidat," oil on canvas, 70" x 54" (1959).

Kierkegaard, the 19th century Danish philosopher now regarded as the classic existentialist, and late in life painted an especially beautiful imaginary portrait of him. A few studies in colored pencils, colored inks and casein are also included in the exhibit.

Painting so inventive and bold which does not build on previous achievement inevitably risks failures. For me, *Ergabix* does not cohere. I also believe that the paintings with two figures are less suggestive than the solitaires. The pairs remind me of the art of Francis Bacon without the sadomasochistic angst.

Ergabix brings up the question of Sievan's curious titles. Among the others are *Peramboor*, *Iseboor* and *Oogalik*. He once explained that the sound was intended to suggest the quality of the experience the artist had in creating the picture. Incidentally, painting was a vigorous and exhausting physical struggle for Sievan.

Maurice Sievan and his wife Lee spent their summers for a few decades at Byrdcliffe. Illness confined him to his apartment in New York after the mid-1970s, and he died there in 1981. For several decades Lee photographed him, and recent solo exhibits of her beautiful portraits were held in Florida and New York City. ++

Tram Combs

MAURICE SIEVAN: Major figurative paintings of the 50s and 60s. Vanderwoude Tananbaum Gallery, 24 E. 81st Street, New York. 3/1-4/2/83.